

In which parts of an initiative's life-cycle are different types of evaluation used?

It is useful to think of different types of evaluation being used at different stages in an initiative's life cycle. This Different Types of Evaluation Over an Initiative's Life-Cycle Tool (G4) shows the points at which evaluation resources can be used and which types of evaluation to use. The tool can be used for undertaking either a formal or informal 'evaluability assessment' of an initiative. An evaluability assessment checks to see if an initiative's implementation is sound and mature enough for it to be worthwhile to do an impact evaluation.

In such a situation, you can use this tool to highlight that the best use of evaluation resources may not be to just spend them on impact evaluation. For example, it might be better to spend some, or all, evaluation funding on implementation evaluation, such as developmental or formative evaluation.

The use of implementation evaluation in this tool is related to the idea of 'intervention fidelity' used in impact evaluation. Suppose you are doing an impact evaluation to test Initiative X. In that case, you need to be sure that what is being tested within the evaluation is a faithful version of Initiative X. Otherwise, you are not actually testing whether or not Initiative X works - you are testing whether a somewhat different initiative works. You can check for intervention fidelity by comparing the DoView strategy/outcomes diagram of what is happening in the initiative being evaluated with the DoView diagram for Initiative X.

The tool also includes process evaluation. You use process evaluation first to assist when you are interpreting impact evaluation results. If Initiative X is shown not to have an impact on outcomes, process evaluation can help you work out why. Did key staff leave in the middle of the initiative, etc.? Process evaluation also provides information that can be used within implementation evaluation of future similar initiatives. Impact evaluation might have established that 'Initiative X works'. However, if you are wanting to implement Initiative X elsewhere and want to maximize its chances of success, then you need to make sure that the new implementation is actually similar to Initiative X. As noted above, comparing the DoView strategy/outcomes diagram of the initiative being implemented with Initiative X's DoView will help you do this.